

Identity Data

The postmodern understanding of the human identity, if paraphrased, states that every human being is the product of the intersection of all his or her societal interactions. While this has several philosophical implications, this essentially means that every step an individual takes and every decision he makes can be predicted – as long as there is a sufficient amount of information available to analyze. This is the essence of Identity Data. This particular sub-type is the driving force behind the ability of a machine to learn and predict the way a human will behave. Predictive modeling, as a whole, emerges from the analyses of Identity Data.



With big data, everything is quantifiable. Your shopping habits are your online fingerprints. We are defined by the data that we produce.

It is also the part of Big Data that is most important to security. When hackers stole identity information from AshleyMadison.com, or breached Target's database, the biggest problem both of them faced was the loss of identity data. This was because, to a supermarket like Target, this identity data, coupled with shopping patterns, credit card usage, and social media behavior, could very accurately predict your lifestyle choices, and enable them to advertise more efficiently to you. In the same way, AshleyMadison.com, a cheaters' dating website, could use all this information, plug it into their dating algorithm, and find a better match for their prospective consumers. Websites such as Wired and Slate also use identity data to predict what kind of articles their subscribers are likely to enjoy, and to try and improve on how they bring them the news.

People Data

People Data is the Internet equivalent of a call-center. This is because it is the type of data that is used by companies to treat their customers like they are real human beings. People Data is generally collected through the social interactions of a customer including what social media sites they prefer, where they got the recommendation to first stumble upon the website of said